

Acme Corp Employee Handbook

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Welcome to Acme Corp.

This handbook is the general guide to working here. It covers how we expect people to behave, how the everyday processes work, and where to go when something is wrong.

It is not a contract of employment. Where this handbook and your contract disagree, your contract applies. Where this handbook and a specific policy disagree, the specific policy applies ? the HR Policy for leave and notice, the Information Security Policy for security controls, the Expense Policy for what can be reclaimed.

The handbook is reviewed annually. The version in the People Portal is always the current one; a printed copy may not be.

1. Working at Acme Corp

1.1 Our Expectations

We expect people to be honest, to treat colleagues with respect, and to do what they said they would do. Most of what follows is an elaboration of those three things.

1.2 Working Hours

The standard working week is 37.5 hours. Core hours, when everyone is expected to be contactable, are 10:00 to 16:00. Outside core hours, arrange your day as suits you and your team.

1.3 Remote Work

Most roles may be worked remotely up to three days a week. Fully remote arrangements are possible with director approval and a workstation assessment.

Remote does not mean unavailable. Keep your calendar accurate, and say where you are working from if it is not your usual place.

1.4 The Office

Offices are open from 07:00 to 20:00 on weekdays. Access outside those hours requires a badge permission, granted on request.

Desks are unallocated. Book one through the desk booking tool if you are coming in on a busy day.

2. Code of Conduct

2.1 Respect

Harassment, bullying and discrimination are not tolerated. This applies to conduct in the office, at company events, online, and in any setting connected to work.

If you experience or witness this, you can raise it informally with your manager, formally through the grievance procedure in section 5, or confidentially through the speak-up line.

2.2 Conflicts of Interest

Declare anything that could reasonably be seen as a conflict. Outside work, a directorship, a family relationship with a supplier, a financial interest in a competitor. Declaring something is not an admission that it is a problem; most declared conflicts need no action.

2.3 Gifts and Hospitality

Gifts above 50 GBP may not be accepted. Hospitality may be accepted where it is proportionate and openly offered. Anything from a public official requires prior legal review.

The gifts register is maintained by Legal.

2.4 Confidentiality

Company and customer information stays inside the company. This survives the end of employment.

2.5 Speaking Publicly

Speaking at a conference or writing publicly about your work is encouraged. Clear the content with your director first if it touches on customers, unreleased products, or financial information.

3. Health, Safety and Wellbeing

3.1 Responsibilities

Acme Corp is responsible for providing a safe place to work. Everyone is responsible for working safely and for reporting hazards.

3.2 Reporting Accidents

All accidents, however minor, are recorded in the accident book at reception or through the online form. Near misses should be reported too: they are the cheapest way to find a hazard.

3.3 First Aid and Fire

First aiders and fire wardens are listed by the lifts on each floor. The fire alarm is tested on Wednesday mornings at 09:30. If it sounds at any other time, leave by the nearest exit and go to the assembly point.

3.4 Display Screen Equipment

Everyone working regularly at a screen is entitled to an assessment, in the office or at home. Eye tests are paid for by the company, along with a contribution towards glasses where they are needed specifically for screen work.

3.5 Wellbeing Support

The employee assistance programme is free, confidential, and available 24 hours a day to employees and their immediate family. It covers counselling, legal and financial guidance.

Mental health first aiders are listed alongside the physical first aiders.

4. Disciplinary Procedure

4.1 Principles

The procedure is intended to be fair, consistent and proportionate. Its purpose is to improve conduct rather than to punish.

You have the right to be accompanied at any formal meeting by a colleague or a trade union representative.

4.2 Informal Resolution

Most concerns are resolved informally by a conversation with your manager. An informal conversation is not a disciplinary step and is not recorded on your file.

4.3 Formal Stages

Stage one is a written warning, live for 6 months.

Stage two is a final written warning, live for 12 months.

Stage three is dismissal, with notice or with pay in lieu.

Stages may be skipped where the conduct is serious enough to warrant it.

4.4 Gross Misconduct

Gross misconduct may result in summary dismissal without notice. Examples include theft, fraud, violence, deliberate damage, serious breaches of the Information Security Policy, and falsifying an expense claim.

Where gross misconduct is alleged, you may be suspended on full pay while it is investigated. Suspension is not a disciplinary sanction and is not an assumption of guilt.

4.5 Appeals

You may appeal any formal sanction within 10 working days. The appeal is heard by a manager not previously involved. The appeal decision is final.

5. Grievance Procedure

5.1 Informal Stage

An employee should first discuss a grievance informally with their line manager. Many issues are resolved at this stage, and doing so is not a lesser outcome.

Where the grievance concerns the line manager, raise it with that manager's manager or with People Operations instead.

5.2 Formal Stage

If the matter is not resolved informally, submit a formal written grievance to People Operations, setting out what happened, who was involved, and what outcome you are seeking.

People Operations must acknowledge the grievance within 5 working days and hold a hearing within 15 working days.

5.3 The Hearing

You may be accompanied. The hearing is chaired by a manager not previously involved. You will be given the opportunity to explain the grievance and to suggest how it might be resolved.

5.4 The Outcome

The outcome is given in writing within 10 working days of the hearing, with reasons.

5.5 Appeal

You may appeal within 10 working days of receiving the outcome. The appeal is heard by a more senior manager, and that decision is final.

5.6 Collective Grievances

Where a grievance is raised by several employees about the same matter, it may be heard as a collective grievance with a nominated representative.

6. Probation

6.1 The Probation Period

Probation terms are set out in the HR Policy and are not repeated here.

In summary, new employees serve a probation period, reviews are held part way through and at the end, and the outcome is confirmed in writing.

6.2 What Probation Affects

While on probation you are not eligible for the discretionary bonus scheme, the training budget, or unpaid leave.

International travel during probation requires additional approval, as set out in the Travel Booking Policy.

Your notice period during probation is shorter than the standard notice period; the exact terms are in the HR Policy.

6.3 Support During Probation

Probation is a two-way assessment. You should expect regular one-to-ones, a clear plan for the first three months, and a buddy who is not your manager.

If something is not working, say so early. A probation period that ends badly is almost always one where a problem was visible for weeks and not discussed.

6.4 After Probation

On successful completion you are enrolled in the private medical scheme, the standard notice period applies, and the full benefits package becomes available.

7. Leaving Acme Corp